

COMPLETE CHESS LEARNING LIBRARY

Middlegame Plans and Piece Jobs

Worst-piece repair, restriction, outposts, exchanges, and plan triggers

TRAINING WORKBOOK

20 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

Workbook Method

Attempt each page before reopening the matching course-book chapter. Speak answers aloud or write them. The self-score rewards a clear decision rule and the opponent's best reply, not a lucky move guess.

REVIEW THRESHOLD

8-10: review in one week. 5-7: review tomorrow. 0-4: reread the course chapter now, then retry from a blank board.

Use the workbook again after a game reaches a related structure. Real-game retrieval is the final test.

01. Find the Worst Piece



MIDDLEGAME PLANS AND PIECE JOBS

POSITION PROMPT

The least useful piece often reveals the correct quiet move.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

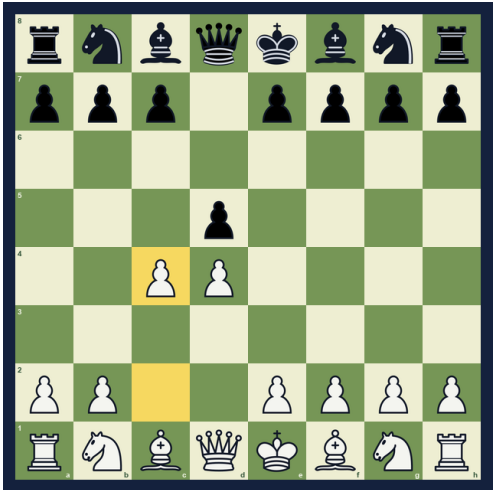
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

4. Which piece has the least useful job?

5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

02. Knight Routes in d4-c4 Positions



MIDDLEGAME PLANS AND PIECE JOBS

POSITION PROMPT

Knights often travel through d2-f1-g3, e1-d3, or c3-a4-c5.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

03. Free the Bad Bishop



MIDDLEGAME PLANS AND PIECE JOBS

POSITION PROMPT

A bishop trapped by its own pawns needs a pawn break or route outside the chain.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5 Be7 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd3 Nbd7 8. Qc2 Re8 9. Nge2 Nf8 10. O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

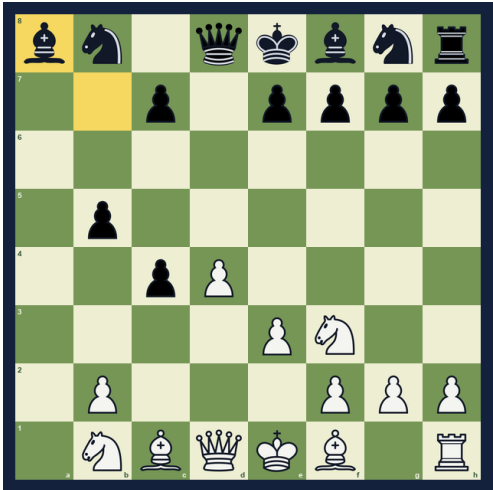
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

04. Use the Light Bishop Correctly



MIDDLEGAME PLANS AND PIECE JOBS

POSITION PROMPT

Bd3, Be2, g2, and c4 serve different structures.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 a6 4. e3 b5 5. a4 Bb7 6. axb5 axb5 7. Rxa8 Bxa8

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

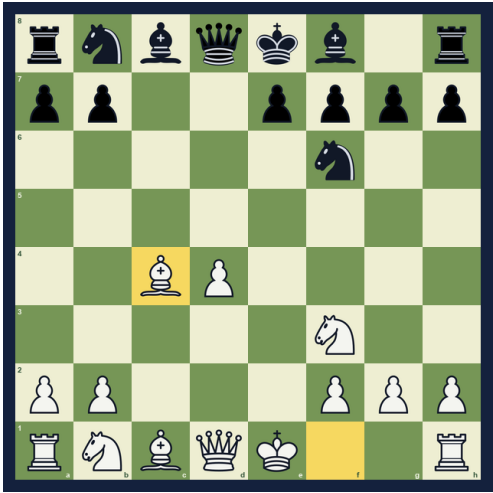
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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FORECAST	__ / 2

05. Queen Placement as Support



MIDDLEGAME PLANS AND PIECE JOBS

POSITION PROMPT

The queen supports breaks, recaptures, and entry squares but is vulnerable to tempi.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 c5 4. e3 cxd4 5. exd4 Nf6 6. Bxc4

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

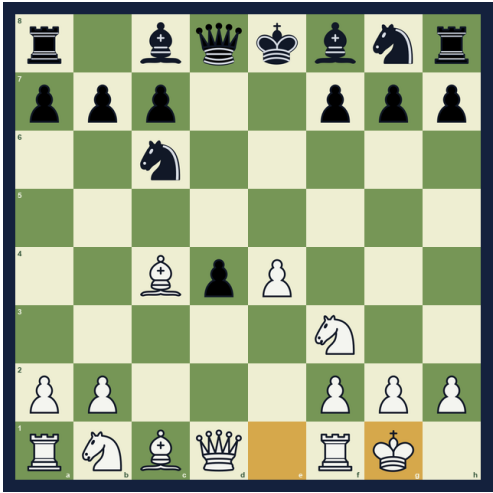
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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

06. Rooks on c, d, and e Files



MIDDLEGAME PLANS AND PIECE JOBS

POSITION PROMPT

Central transformations decide which rook file matters.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. e4 e5 4. Nf3 exd4 5. Bxc4 Nc6 6. O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

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- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

07. Occupy an Outpost



MIDDLEGAME PLANS AND PIECE JOBS

POSITION PROMPT

e5, c5, d6, and e6 become outposts when pawns cannot challenge them.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bg5 Be7 7. Qc2 O-O 8. e3 Nbd7 9. Bd3 Re8 10. O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

08. Use Space Without Overextending



MIDDLEGAME PLANS AND PIECE JOBS

POSITION PROMPT

Space gives maneuvering room and restricts Black but can create targets.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bg5 Be7 7. Qc2 O-O 8. e3 Nbd7 9. Bd3 Re8 10. O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

09. Practical Prophylaxis



MIDDLEGAME PLANS AND PIECE JOBS

POSITION PROMPT

Black's freeing break is often more important than White's dream move.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bg5 Be7 7. Qc2 O-O 8. e3 Nbd7 9. Bd3 Re8 10. O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

10. Restriction Before Expansion



MIDDLEGAME PLANS AND PIECE JOBS

POSITION PROMPT

A queenside or kingside expansion is safer after Black's counterplay is contained.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e3 O-O 6. Nf3 h6 7. Bh4 b6 8. cxd5 exd5 9. Bd3 Bb7 10. O-O Nbd7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

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- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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11. Queenside Expansion



MIDDLEGAME PLANS AND PIECE JOBS

POSITION PROMPT

b4-b5, a4-a5, and c5 gain space and create files.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Be7 5. Bf4 O-O 6. e3 c5 7. dxc5 Bxc5 8. Qc2 Nc6 9. Rd1 Qa5 10. a3

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

12. Center Versus Wing



MIDDLEGAME PLANS AND PIECE JOBS

POSITION PROMPT

A wing attack can fail if the center can open against the king.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Bb4 5. cxd5 exd5 6. Bg5 h6 7. Bh4 c5 8. e3 Nc6 9. Bd3 cxd4 10. exd4 O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

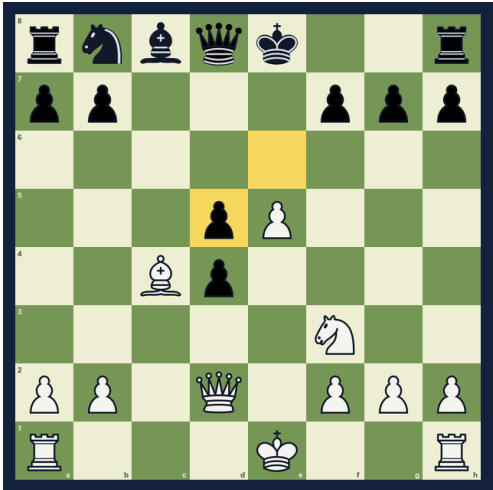
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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FORECAST	__ / 2

13. Bishop Pair Decisions



MIDDLEGAME PLANS AND PIECE JOBS

POSITION PROMPT

The bishop pair grows stronger as the position opens.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 dxc4 5. e4 Bb4 6. e5 Nd5 7. Bd2 c5 8. Bxc4 cxd4 9. Nxd5 Bxd2+ 10. Qxd2 exd5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

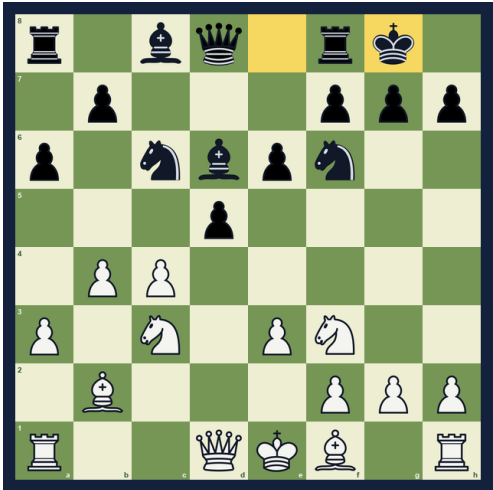
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FORECAST	__ / 2

14. Good Bishop, Bad Bishop



MIDDLEGAME PLANS AND PIECE JOBS

POSITION PROMPT

Judge a bishop by targets and future pawn moves, not only current pawn color.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 c5 4. e3 Nf6 5. Nf3 Nc6 6. a3 a6 7. dxc5 Bxc5 8. b4 Bd6 9. Bb2 O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

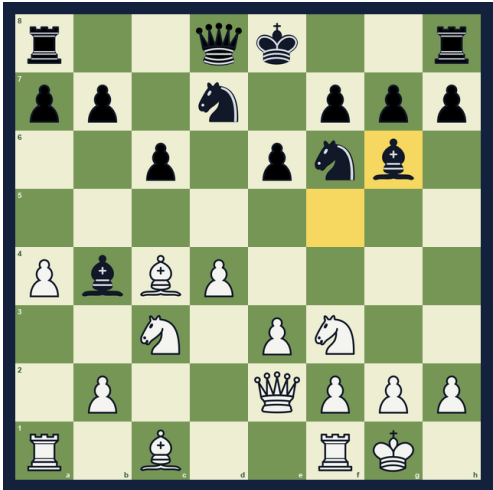
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FORECAST	__ / 2

15. Entry Squares



MIDDLEGAME PLANS AND PIECE JOBS

POSITION PROMPT

File control matters when a rook or queen can penetrate to the seventh rank or a fixed target.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 dxc4 5. a4 Bf5 6. e3 e6 7. Bxc4 Bb4 8. O-O Nbd7 9. Qe2 Bg6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

16. Create a Second Weakness



MIDDLEGAME PLANS AND PIECE JOBS

POSITION PROMPT

One weakness is often defendable because pieces can cluster around it.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 a6 5. c5 Bf5 6. Bf4 Nbd7 7. e3 Nh5 8. Bg5 h6 9. Bh4 g5 10. Bg3 Nxc3 11. hxc3 Bg7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

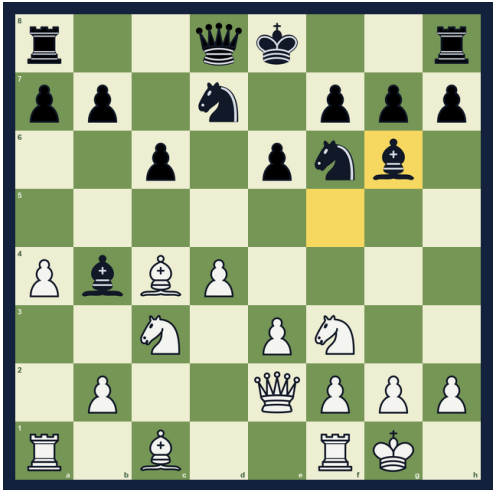
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FORECAST	__ / 2

17. Attack or Convert



MIDDLEGAME PLANS AND PIECE JOBS

POSITION PROMPT

A temporary initiative demands speed; a lasting structural edge permits improvement.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 dxc4 5. a4 Bf5 6. e3 e6 7. Bxc4 Bb4 8. O-O Nbd7 9. Qe2 Bg6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

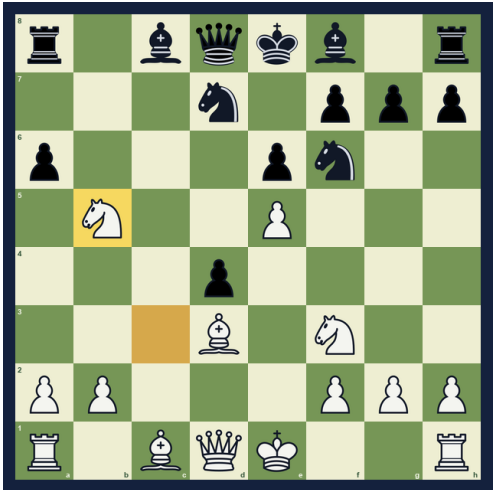
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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

18. Active Defense as White



MIDDLEGAME PLANS AND PIECE JOBS

POSITION PROMPT

Even with space, White may need to answer a tactical break or king attack.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Bd3 dxc4 7. Bxc4 b5 8. Bd3 a6 9. e4 c5 10. e5 cxd4 11. Nxb5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

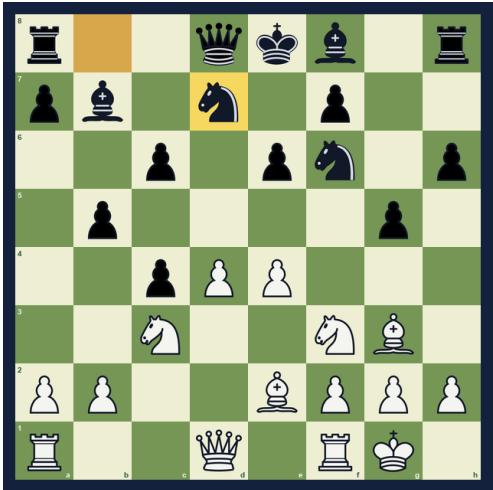
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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

19. Use the Initiative



MIDDLEGAME PLANS AND PIECE JOBS

POSITION PROMPT

Activity is valuable while moves arrive with threats and Black lacks coordination.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. Bg5 h6 6. Bh4 dxc4 7. e4 g5 8. Bg3 b5 9. Be2 Bb7 10. O-O Nbd7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

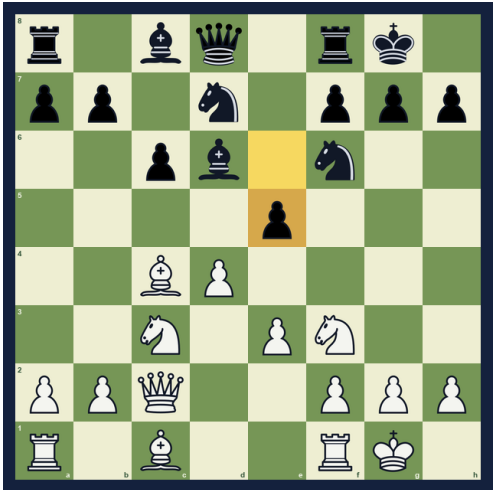
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FORECAST	__ / 2

20. Recognize the Plan Trigger



MIDDLEGAME PLANS AND PIECE JOBS

POSITION PROMPT

Plans change when a pawn captures, a bishop is exchanged, or a break becomes available.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Qc2 Bd6 7. Bd3 O-O 8. O-O dxc4 9. Bxc4 e5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

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Monthly Retention Audit

Select ten random chapters and complete them under a ten-minute total limit. Track the categories you repeatedly miss: threat, candidate, structure, piece job, or forecast.

Do not restart the entire course. Return to the smallest group of chapters that repairs the repeated error, then test again in one week.